Harbor Survey

Field notes for the north basin

Harbor watch 18 October 2026



Figure 1: NASA AS11-40-5874, public domain. The photograph stands in for the site picture that belongs beside these notes.

The morning run started at the inner mole while the tide was still making. Two observers worked the same line: one called ranges from the staff, the other kept the notebook.

Nothing in the first hour suggested a change in the channel. The water stayed a dull green, the wind stayed in the west, and the ferry kept the same five-minute beat. The useful difference showed up where the staff readings stopped agreeing with yesterday.

By 07:40 the north staff was running ahead of the south staff by a quarter of a metre. That is more than the usual set of the flood. The gap held after the ferry passed, so it was not just wash. We marked the line in pencil and agreed to read it again on the ebb.

The south basin drains through a culvert that was clear last week. This morning the culvert mouth carried a braid of weed, and the water on that side rose late. The north side, open to the channel, rose on time. The table is the whole argument: same tide, two different clocks.

Table 1: Staff readings, metres above the sill.

Time	North	South
06:40	1.84	1.79
07:10	2.02	1.91
07:40	2.21	1.96
08:10	2.18	2.04

We do not need a new chart for that. We need the note beside the figures, and the photograph so a reader who was not on the mole can see which staff is which. The rest of the book can stay in the vault as ordinary text.

Come back at the top of the ebb, photograph the culvert mouth, and copy these four lines into the week log. If the south staff is still late, the weed is the cause. If the two sides agree again, the flood simply set harder than the book expected, and this sheet can be filed as a false alarm.

The second reading is the one that settles the argument. At the top of the ebb the north staff had already given back half of the morning rise. The south staff had not. Weed was still braided across the culvert, and a stick dropped on that side took most of a minute to clear the mouth.

That is slow enough to matter. A boat drawing a metre and a half would read the south basin as navigable and then find it was not. The note is here so the next watch does not have to reconstruct the morning from memory.

The photograph stays with the sheet for the same reason. A reader can see the figure, the two columns of the account, and the small table of staff heights without opening another file.

Conclusion. File this with the week log. Photograph the culvert before the next flood. If the south staff matches the north staff on that tide, strike the warning. If it does not, the culvert is the restriction, and the harbor sketch needs a mark at the mouth.